

buy a big block of shares. Prakash asked him which stock he intended to buy.

‘I will know in ten minutes,’ he said.

After ten minutes, his cellphone rang. The conversation lasted barely a couple of minutes.

‘Between 3.30 and 4.00, is it? Okay, tell Michael I will be there at the appointed time to collect the papers. Just in case I miss him, when can he make it next? Okay, tomorrow five o’clock, is it? Fine then.’

As soon as the telephone conversation was over, Tyson placed an order for 50,000 shares of Satyam Computer Services. In less than half an hour, Satyam shares rose by Rs 10. Tyson promptly sold out his position. I had no doubt that Tyson had received the tip during the course of the conversation he had on his mobile phone just before he had placed the order.

‘So, what is it with Michael and the papers?’ I asked, not really expecting an answer. I knew him well enough to take the odd liberty with him. Tyson winked but said nothing. A couple of days later, over a drink, he told me about the code.

‘The time I mentioned represented the last three digits of the BSE code for the scrip, Satyam Computer in this case. The exact code is 376, a number between 350 and 400. The dealer friend of mine had told me the previous evening that he was likely to get a big order for Satyam.

‘When he got the order, he confirmed it to me over the phone, saying that Michael would come over with the papers. Michael here refers to a foreign fund house. If the buyer were a domestic mutual fund, the code word would have been Gopal. I then inquired about the order size indirectly, by asking when he would next make it in case I missed him today. My contact mentioned five o’clock, meaning 5 lakh shares. If we had been discussing a sell order, he would have asked me to come over and collect the papers from Michael.

‘Obviously, we cannot use the same message every time. At other times, we discuss common friends during the conversation, with each name corresponding to a certain stock. The order size is mentioned in terms of the day of the week or month of the calendar. “I will meet Rohan next Wednesday” means the dealer has a buy order of 4 lakh shares in a particular stock. If he says he won’t be able to meet Rohan next Wednesday, it means he has a sell order of 4 lakh shares.